

IPL calling: Monty Desai left Atlanta, USA, and flew to Jaipur to work with IPL franchise Rajasthan Royals as one of its main talent scouts for more than half a decade. EMMANUEL YOGINI



IPL bridges the old and the new, on and off the pitch

Over time, the IPL has emerged as a highly successful global sports league, fostering opportunities **for both current and retired Indian cricketers.**

Shayan Acharya
shayan.acharya@thehindu.co.in

After a lengthy conversation with Zubin Bharucha, Director of High Performance at Rajasthan Royals, over emails and calls, Monty Desai decided to leave Atlanta and travel to Jaipur to explore something new. It was mid-2008, just a few months after the inaugural season of the Indian Premier League (IPL). Despite the presence of cricket legends and

Bollywood superstars, the first edition of the cash-rich league raised more questions than answers. The focus on glamour rather than the game left concerns about the long-term viability of the project and its impact on Indian cricket. However, over the next 16 years, the IPL not only became one of the most successful sports leagues globally but also created opportunities for both current players and retired Indian cricketers.

"One of the first things that Zubin told me back then was that the

league is going to expand and they were looking at an Indian coach for scouting and development work. That's why I came back to India," Desai says.

In that era, the nuances of scouting were not widely understood, and the requirements were unclear. However, franchises such as Rajasthan Royals, Mumbai Indians, and Kolkata Knight Riders displayed foresight by engaging former cricketers to traverse the country and watch countless cricket matches to secure the most